

Peafowl

The same answer for 4 peacocks and peahens found in the manor after the time of the lord king.⁴⁷³ Sum 4, of which 1 was male. Of which he accounts for 1 peahen in murrain by the testimony of the whole homage. Sum 1. And 3 peafowl remain.

Cocks and hens

The same answers for 5 cocks and 5 hens received from rent called 'churchscot' at the feast of Christmas. Sum 10. And he accounts for all sold as within. And it equals.

White-tawed hide

The same answers for half a hide of a horse of white-tawed leather bought as within. And he accounts for half of which in expenses for mending the harness of the cart. And a quarter part of one hide of white-tawed leather remains.

29. 29 September 1335 to 29 September 1336

The account for 1335/6 is a mine of incidental yet illuminating information. For example, it provides many valuable details about the nature of the buildings and landscape at the manorial centre. In particular, the interior furnishing of the service area of the manor – comprising the kitchen, buttery, pantry, and bakehouse – was renewed, while shelves were made for the lord's chamber and fixed using ropes made from hemp. Outside, references to 'the hedged enclosure' around the chapel confirm that this was a freestanding structure; it was not necessarily surrounded by a green sward, however, for this year saw the enclosure being ploughed up for cultivation.⁴⁷⁴ Elsewhere, a postern gate was made next to the lord's chamber leading towards the riverbank and steps were made down to the river itself. The account also provides unusual insights into the lives of the bishop, his tenants, and other locals. The men of the lord king (and presumably the king himself) were present at Esher for 'discussion', plausibly with regard to Bishop de Orleton's role as an ambassador to the French court during the summer of 1336. Perhaps of most enduring historical significance, though, is the list of grain received from the rectories of Esher and Cobham, for – as with tithe receipts in 1247/8 (doc. 4) – this provides a snapshot of the crops grown and harvested by local peasants, from whom the rectory collected tithes.⁴⁷⁵ What is immediately striking, as discussed in the introduction, is the extent to which peasants at both Esher and Cobham now appear to have relied almost exclusively on oats for nutrition and perhaps for sale. The accounts also suggest that these peasants were not alone in facing challenging times. Indeed, Sandon Priory seems to have lain empty this year, the prior of Sandon instead being prominent in the management of the bishop's manor in a hands-on capacity; as the collection of tithes suggests, there were also vacancies in the benefices of Cobham and – as the account for the following years specifies – Esher.⁴⁷⁶

⁴⁷³ That is, during the episcopal vacancy, when the manor reverted to the king.

⁴⁷⁴ Our picture of the chapel is further enhanced by a passing reference in this account to the chamber that lay beneath it.

⁴⁷⁵ For recent, pioneering work on peasant agriculture using tithe returns, see Dodds, 'Demesne and tithe'; and Sapoznik, 'Resource allocation'.

⁴⁷⁶ The collection and recording of tithes by the manorial administration suggests that the bishop was short-circuiting the process of sending in his sequestrator to receive the fruits of the benefice.

HRO, 11M59/B1/88, rot 13r.

Account there for the third year of the translation of Lord Adam, bishop of Winchester.

Arrears

Hugh de Wynterore, reeve, renders account for 49s ½d of arrears from his last account for the preceding year. Sum 49s ½d.

Rent of assize

The same answers for £6 22½d from fixed rent at Esher for the year, of which at the feast of the Invention of the Cross [3 May] 10s 3d. Sum £6 22½d.

Defects of rent

In defect for a certain house and land pertaining to the church drawn into demesne 20s. In defect for 1 rood of meadow formerly of Legarda atte Hulle drawn into demesne 1d. In defect for 1 rood of meadow formerly of Albreda atte Hulle drawn into demesne 1d. Sum 20s 2d.

Allowances

In allowance of rent of the reeve for the year 3s. Sum 3s. Sum of acquittances and defects 23s 2d.

Sum of net rent remaining £4 18s 8½d.

Rent of Kingston

The same answers for 2s received from one plot of land of the curtilage at Kingston newly leased there. Sum 2s.

Issue of the manor

The same answers for 8d from the fishery of Northwode sold. And for 2d from pannage of 1 pig and 2 young pigs of Henry atte Frythe this year and not more from pannage because Richard atte Barre did not have pigs. And for 11s received from the mast from all the woods of the manor sold wholesale by view of the prior of Sandon. And for 26s 8d received from winter and summer pasture sold this year at Northwode. And for 2s from pasture in La Crombe sold. And for 18d from pasture sold in Le Frith. And for 6d from pasture sold in La Cherchgrove. And for 4s 6d from pasture in La More sold. And for 6d from pasture in the warren. And for 4s from pasture and small withies in one croft sold. From pasture of Longeforlang and Bobbecompe nothing this year because of the lord's sheep depasturing and also lying fallow and manuring. From pasture in Le Dounwode nothing this year because it was sown. From fruit in the garden nothing this year. And for 15d received from 5 cocks and 5 hens from 'churchscot' sold. And for 18d from 1 young sow sold, by order of the prior of Sandon. And for 16d from two hides of horses sold. And for 7d from the hide of 1 mare sold. And for 39s 7½d from hay sold to the lord's household. And for 20d from 5 piglets sold. And for 6d from one tunic from the heriot of Albreda atte Hulle sold. Sum £4 18s ½d.

Sale of corn

The same renders account for 20d from 1 quarter 2 bushels of 'drauk'⁴⁷⁷ sold, price of a bushel 2d. Sum 20d.

Fines

And for 12d from Richard Derlyng for having 1 acre of land in Le Cleye next to the land of Morwyne in Esher, surrendered by Alice la Forstyer. And for 20d from Christina, daughter of Albreda atte Hulle, for having one messuage, 1 acre and 1 rood of land in Esher that was the aforesaid Albreda, her mother's. And for 12d from John atte Wode for having one plot of curtilage called Collardeshawe in Esher containing 1 rood of land, surrendered by Richard Sewyne. Sum 3s 8d.

Perquisites of court

The same answers for 8s from a fixed payment at the view of frankpledge with its tithings for tithingpenny at the tourns of St Martin and Hockday. And for 17s 9d from the perquisites of the tourn of St Martin. And for 7s from the perquisites of the tourn of Hockday. And for 4s 1d from the perquisites of a court held on the Monday next after the feast of the Exaltation of the Cross [16 September]. And for 12d from the perquisites of the hall of Kingston, namely from John Trassh and William Prantys for the assize of ale. Sum 37s 10d.

Foreign receipts

The same answers for 13s 4d received from Master Nicholas de Kaerwent, without tally. And for £13 14½d from 184 quarters 1 peck of oats sold to the lord's household. And for 4s 8d from straw from Cobham⁴⁷⁸ sold. Sum £13 19s 2½d.

Sales at the audit

And for 6s 8½d from things sold at the audit. Sum 6s 8½d.

Sum of all receipts with arrears £28 16s 10½d.

Payment of rent

Of which the same accounts as paid to the lord abbot of Chertsey for the land of Northwode at the feast of St Michael 6s. And to the same for two ploughshares at the same term 18d. Sum 7s 6d.

Cost of ploughs

The same accounts for iron and steel bought for one plough with the stipend of a smith for the year 3s 6d and so much this year because of a drought.⁴⁷⁹ Likewise in two plough feet bought this year 6d. In covering one plough with boards and fitting it with a chip 2d. In stipend of one ploughdriver for the year 5s. In stipend of one boy harrowing between the feast of St Michael and the feast of St Thomas the Apostle [21 December] 6d. Sum 9s 8d.

⁴⁷⁷ This suggests that part of the wheat crop was infested with a mixture of weeds.

⁴⁷⁸ In MS, 'Coveham' (and likewise below, in the grain and stock accounts).

⁴⁷⁹ June and July were reportedly very dry (Kington, *Climate and weather*, p. 227); ground conditions were possibly exacerbated by a hydrological deficit following the droughts of the 1320s and early 1330s.

Customary payments to customary tenants

The same accounts for 28 herrings bought for an accompaniment for 14 customary tenants harrowing demesne land at the sowing of oats for one day $2\frac{3}{4}$ d, each taking two herrings and bread from stock as elsewhere. Sum $2\frac{3}{4}$ d.

Cost of carts with shoeing of horses

The same accounts for twice fitting one cart with an axle, with axles bought for the same 6d. In 16 clouts with nails bought for the cart this year, for the great carriage of wood, charcoal, and other necessities 16d. In 100 clout nails bought $1\frac{1}{2}$ d. Likewise in grease for the cart this year 16d. In one hemp rope bought for the cart, of 10 fathoms, 8d. In one base bought for the saddle of the cart 6d. In two halters bought 2d. Likewise in shoeing 5 affers for the year, of which 2 for half the year and 1 for three-quarters of the year 4s 9d. In stipend of one carter for the year 5s. Sum 14s $4\frac{1}{2}$ d.

Purchase of corn

The same accounts for 1 quarter 5 bushels of wheat bought for sowing 8s $1\frac{1}{2}$ d, price of a bushel $7\frac{1}{2}$ d. Likewise in 3 quarters of rye bought for sowing 12s, price of a quarter 4s. In 1 quarter $2\frac{1}{2}$ bushels of rye bought for payment of the *famuli* 4s $9\frac{3}{4}$ d, price of a bushel $5\frac{1}{2}$ d. Likewise in 7 quarters 2 bushels of oats bought for fodder 9s 8d, price of a quarter 16d. Sum 34s $7\frac{1}{4}$ d.

Small things and necessities

The same accounts for one carpenter to make a stall in the oxshed for 6 oxen, inclusively, 4d. Likewise in clearing and fencing 175 perches of ditch and bank by piecework, by order of the lord, by the view of John Seint Jon, between the wood and the manorial close and against the tenement of Richard Derlyng and next to the manorial granary 21s $10\frac{1}{2}$ d, namely for clearing and fencing a perch $1\frac{1}{2}$ d. Likewise in one man for felling fencing for the same fence for 17 days and for felling wood for firewood for $6\frac{1}{2}$ days 3s 11d, for a day 2d. Likewise in fencing 35 perches of fence by piecework behind the grange and between the hedged enclosure of the chapel⁴⁸⁰ and the clerks' chamber $17\frac{1}{2}$ d, for a perch $\frac{1}{2}$ d. In one man for two days for making poles from willows for planting 4d. In one carpenter for two days to make two racks in the stable 6d. In making one fence in the *curia*, inclusively, by a contract made with R de Hoo, 16d. In 500 nails bought for the same 10d. In hooks and hinges for a gate for the same 4d. Likewise in two carts of hay bought for sustenance for the manorial affers by view of the prior of Sandon 6s 8d. In digging the whole curtilage of the hedged enclosure of the chapel, inclusively, for cultivating 12d, by view of John Seint John. In one lock with a key for the postern gate towards the wood 3d. In one man for two days to mend the wall within the close and without 4d. Sum 39s 2d.

Cost of the sheephouse

The same accounts for 26 hurdles bought for the fold 3s 3d, price of a hurdle $1\frac{1}{2}$ d. Likewise in customary payment to seven customary tenants for washing the lord's sheep for a day and shearing for half a day, namely after lunch, by custom $5\frac{1}{4}$ d, each

⁴⁸⁰ In MS, 'chapelhagh'.

taking after completing the work $\frac{3}{4}$ d. And know that each customary tenant sheared 16 sheep this year. Likewise paid for washing and shearing 127 wethers by piecework $6\frac{1}{2}$ d, namely for 20 1d. Likewise in tar pitch and grease bought for making salve from which 6d. In stipend of one shepherd for the year 5s. In stipend of a second shepherd for half the year, in summer, 3s. Sum 12s $8\frac{3}{4}$ d.

Mending of buildings

And the same accounts for 1,400 plain tiles bought 4s 2d, price of a thousand 3s. In $2\frac{1}{2}$ quarters of lime for the same 2s 6d. In one tiler with his helper for tiling for seven days on the clerks' chamber and the brewhouse 3s 6d, for a day 6d. In one roofer with his helper for four days for roofing with straw on the manorial grange 20d, for a day 5d. Likewise in tiling one place in the kitchen for a fire, to make one hearth⁴⁸¹ from small tiles, 8d. In one carpenter for five days for making two troughs for the bakehouse, one gutter and one window⁴⁸² in the kitchen, and one screen in the buttery 15d, for a day 3d. In 100 large nails for the same 5d. Likewise in one carpenter for 14 days for making one door, one pair of shelves, and one screen in the lord's chamber, one sideboard⁴⁸³ and one garner⁴⁸⁴ in the pantry for bread, one screen in one chamber of the kitchen, one screen in the chamber of Walter de Masselinton, and for making four benches 3s 6d, for a day as before. In 300 nails bought for the same 9d. Likewise in sawing 300 feet of boards for the same 2s, for a hundred 8d. In hooks and hinges bought for the aforesaid door 5d. In three iron bolts and one pair of garnet-hinges⁴⁸⁵ for the door of the lord's chamber and for the shelves for the same and for the postern gate to the wood 8d. In two ropes of hemp bought for drawing the aforesaid shelves and said postern gate 4d. Likewise in one pair of garnet-hinges for the door of the chamber of Walter de Maselynton and two hinges for the door of the chamber under the chapel 12d. In one carpenter for five days for scappling one trunk and making one postern door towards the riverbank,⁴⁸⁶ next to the lord's chamber and for making steps towards the aforesaid river, by order of the lord 20d, for a day 4d because it was in the summer.⁴⁸⁷ Likewise in sawing 275 feet of boards from the aforesaid trunk 22d, for a hundred 8d. In 50 nails for the said door $1\frac{1}{2}$ d. In hooks and hinges for the same 6d. In one lock with a key for the same 3d. Sum 27s $2\frac{1}{2}$ d.

Threshing corn

The same accounts for threshing 10 quarters 6 bushels of wheat and 6 quarters of rye by piecework 2s $9\frac{1}{2}$ d, for a quarter 2d. Likewise in threshing 37 quarters 3 bushels of oats by piecework 3s 1d, for a quarter 1d. From henceforth he will not have allowance unless for a quarter $\frac{3}{4}$ d. Likewise in winnowing the aforesaid 54 quarters 1 bushel of all corn by piecework $13\frac{1}{2}$ d, for a quarter $\frac{1}{4}$ d. Sum 7s.

⁴⁸¹ In MS, in English, 'hurth'.

⁴⁸² Possibly a serving hatch.

⁴⁸³ The words '*speer*', '*speer*', and '*spee*' all appear in this and the previous sentence, seemingly interchangeably, denoting a 'speer' or screen. Latham, ed., *Revised medieval Latin word-list*, however, gives 'sideboard' as a possible alternative translation, which seems more appropriate in this context.

⁴⁸⁴ Presumably a small store for flour.

⁴⁸⁵ T-shaped hinges.

⁴⁸⁶ In MS, '*Ripam Aque*', 'bank of the water'.

⁴⁸⁷ Presumably indicating that he was paid more for working longer days.

Weeding and mowing

The same accounts for weeding all the demesne corn this year at Esher and Northwode 12d. Likewise in expenses of customary tenants mowing the meadow of Brodemed: bread from stock; for an accompaniment 1 wether from stock, as shown elsewhere. Likewise in mowing the meadow of Hullemed, La Lake, and the meadow formerly of Legarda atte Hulle, together with lifting up the hay from which this year, 18d, and all was carried with the manorial cart. Sum 2s 6d.

Cost of harvest

The same accounts for the expenses of two wet boons of 46 customary tenants reaping and binding 2½ acres of wheat, 12½ acres of rye, 4 acres of barley, and 22½ acres of oats at Esher for two days, each for one day: bread from stock; in 276 herrings bought for an accompaniment for the same 2s 3½d, for a hundred 10d, each customary tenant taking in a day for two meals six herrings by custom; in cheese bought for the same 6d. In candles 2d. In reaping and binding 3½ acres of oats by piecework at Esher 17½d, for an acre 5d, because it was not able to be done by customary tenants. Likewise in reaping and binding 4 acres of wheat, 17 acres of rye, and 9 acres of oats by piecework at Northwode 13s 9d, namely for an acre of wheat and rye 6d and for an acre of oats 5d. Likewise in a wage paid to John le Welshe being hayward in harvest, by order of the lord and steward, for four weeks 3s 6d, taking for a day 1½d, because [he was] from the lord's *famuli*. Likewise in stipend of the reeve in harvest by custom 2s. Sum 23s 8d.

Stipend of the famuli

The same accounts for the stipend of John Seint John, hayward, for half a year 2s. Sum 2s.

Foreign expenses

19d.⁴⁸⁸

Expenses of the steward

The same accounts for the expenses of Robert de Hoo, steward, holding the tourn of St Martin on the Tuesday on the morrow of the Annunciation of the Blessed Virgin Mary [26 March]⁴⁸⁹ 4s, by one schedule sealed with his signet. Sum 4s.

Sum of all expenses £9 6s 2¾d.

And he owes £19 10s 7¾d.

Allowances without writ

To the reeve a small allowance of 28s 1d for payments and expenditure in the expenses of the household as shown by particulars, as above, struck out in foreign expenses.⁴⁹⁰ And for 10s from hay received from the rectory and used in the lord's household in the past year, none of which had been allowed. Sum 38s 1d.

⁴⁸⁸ No detail is given.

⁴⁸⁹ The feast of St Martin falls on 11 November.

⁴⁹⁰ Not only does this explain the absence of detail in the 'Foreign expenses' paragraph above, but it also confirms the existence, originally, of a reeve's account, from which this formal copy was made.

Allowances by writ

And allowed to the same £15 7s 2d paid to Lord Nicholas de Kaerwent, steward of the lord's household, by six indentures of various dates, of which in 184 quarters 1 peck of oats £13 14½d, in 5 piglets 20d, in hay from the stock of the manor of Esher 39s 7½d, in straw 4s 8d. Sum £15 7s 2d.

Payments of money

And paid to Lord John de Nubbelegh, treasurer of Wolvesey, 20s, by one tally. Sum 20s.

Sum of all allowances and payments £18 5s 3d.

And he owes net 25s 4¾d.

Wheat

It answers seven times less 5 bushels. Wheat. The same answers for 10 quarters 6 bushels of weak and impure wheat received from issue of the grange, threshed by piecework, by tally against John Seint Jon, hayward, of which 1 quarter 2 bushels was 'drauk'. And for 1 quarter 5 bushels of wheat bought for sowing. Sum 12 quarters 3 bushels. Of which he accounts as sown over 4 acres at Northwode and 2½ acres below La Croumbe 1 quarter 5 bushels, thus an acre takes 2 bushels. Likewise to mixed corn for payment of the *famuli*, as below, 9½ quarters of weak and impure wheat. Sold 1 quarter 2 bushels of 'drauk'. Sum as above. And it equals.

Rye

The same answers for 6 quarters of rye received from issue of the grange, threshed by piecework, by tally against the aforesaid John. And for 9 quarters 5 bushels of rye received from the prior of Sandon by tally from issue at the rectory of Esher. And for 4 quarters 2½ bushels bought for sowing and for payment of the *famuli*. Sum 19 quarters 7½ bushels. Of which he accounts as sown over 17 acres at Northwode and 12½ acres at Esher 7 quarters 3 bushels, over an acre 2 bushels. Likewise in expenses of 14 customary tenants harrowing for one day at the sowing of oats 1 bushel by custom. Likewise in expenses of the same mowing the meadow of Brodemed 3 bushels by custom. And in expenses of the same for two dry boons in harvest 6 bushels. And to mixed corn for making payments, as below, 11 quarters 2½ bushels. Sum as above. And it equals.

Barley

The same answers for 2 quarters of barley received from the prior of Sandon by tally, from issue of the rectory. And he accounts for all sown over 4 acres at Ryhulle. And thus it equals.

Oats

It answers twice itself plus 1 quarter 2 bushels. The same answers for 28 quarters of oats received from the issue of the grange threshed by piecework, by tally against John Seint John. And for 107 quarters of oats received from the same John by tally from the issue of the rectory of Cobham, of which 15½ quarters were large oats. And for 66 quarters 5 bushels of oats received from the prior of Sandon by tally from

the issue of the rectory of Esher, of which $21\frac{1}{2}$ quarters were large oats. And for 7 quarters 2 bushels of oats bought as within for fodder. And for 9 quarters 3 bushels of oats received from issue of the manorial grange from new grain threshed by piecework for fodder for the lord's horses, by tally against the said prior, of which $6\frac{1}{2}$ quarters were large oats. Sum 218 quarters 2 bushels. Of which he accounts as sown over 26 acres at Esher and 9 acres at Northwode $17\frac{1}{2}$ quarters, thus an acre takes 4 bushels, of which of large oats 7 quarters 2 bushels. Likewise in pottage for the *famuli* for the year 2 quarters. Likewise in fodder for 2 manorial stots for the year for the carriage of various things at the coming of the lord this year 4 quarters. Likewise in fodder for the horses of Robert Petit for one visit 1 quarter 1 bushel, by one tally sealed with his signet. Likewise in a gift to the men of the lord king remaining at Esher 1 quarter 2 bushels, by order of Lord Robert de Alle, for a time of discussion.⁴⁹¹ In fodder for the horses of Lord William de Edyndon and many horses of the lord and retinue for one night after the return of the lord from⁴⁹² overseas parts 3 quarters 2 bushels 2 pecks, by one schedule.⁴⁹³ Sold to the lord's household 184 quarters 1 peck. Sold at the audit 5 quarters 1 peck for 6s $8\frac{1}{2}$ d.

Payment of the famuli

The same answers for $9\frac{1}{2}$ quarters of weak wheat as above received for payment of the *famuli*. And for 11 quarters $2\frac{1}{2}$ bushels of rye as above received for the same. Sum 20 quarters $6\frac{1}{2}$ bushels. Of which accounted for in payment of John Seint John, hayward, taking a quarter for eight weeks from the feast of St Michael until the feast of Pentecost, which was the 19th day of May this year, for 33 weeks 4 quarters 1 bushel. Likewise in payment of one other hayward by the stipulation of the lord, taking his corn as the aforesaid John, for one week, namely the last week of September, 1 bushel. Likewise in payment of one ploughman who was also the carter, taking a quarter for 10 weeks for the year 5 quarters $1\frac{1}{2}$ bushels. In payment of one ploughdriver and one shepherd who each took a quarter for 12 weeks for the year 8 quarters 5 bushels. Likewise in payment of one shepherd guarding 240 wethers of the lord from purchase, taking a quarter for 12 weeks from the 23rd day of May until the feast of St Michael for 18 weeks $1\frac{1}{2}$ quarters. In payment of one boy harrowing at winter sowing and driving the plough on occasion when the carter was occupied in carting wood, charcoal, and other necessities for the use of the lord from the feast of St Michael until the feast of St Thomas the Apostle [21 December] for 12 weeks, and afterwards harrowing for eight weeks and at some time driving [the plough] at Northwode, 1 quarter 2 bushels, for a week $\frac{1}{2}$ bushel. Sum as above. And it equals.

Affers

The same answers for 2 affers that remained. And for 2 affers coming from the rectory of Cobham, of which 1 was female. And for 1 female offer coming from stray,

⁴⁹¹ In MS, '*parliamenti*'. As the only parliament held during the period of this account was at York (in March 1336), and in light of the following entry in the account, this presumably refers to discussions held between the bishop and the king at Esher.

⁴⁹² In MS, '*v[er]sus*'.

⁴⁹³ Bishop de Orleton led an embassy to the French court between 21 July and 5 September 1336: Haines, *Church and politics*, p. 38. The entry that follows plausibly represents the collection of oats required to feed the assembled horses of the embassy. Whether by good fortune or premeditation, this was gathered in turn from the rectories – and, by extension, probably the inhabitants – of Esher and Cobham.

over a year old. Sum 5. Of which he accounts for 3 in murrain, of which 1 was female, by witness of the prior of Sandon and all the homage. And 2 remain, of which 1 is female.

Oxen

The same answers for 6 oxen that remained. Sum 6. And 6 oxen remain.

Cows

And for 1 cow with its calf owing from a certain mortuary payment at Cobham at the time of the vacancy at the church there. And he accounts for the same with its calf delivered to the reeve of Farnham in the middle of May, by letter of the steward.

Wethers

The same answers for 240 wethers received from Lord William de Wyggeton from a purchase. Sum 240. Of which he accounts in customary payment of the customary tenants mowing the meadow of Brodemed after shearing 1 wether with pelt. Likewise in murrain 3, of which 1 before shearing. Sum 4. And 236 wethers remain.

Pigs and piglets

The same answers for 1 young sow with 5 piglets owing from the rectory of Cobham. Sum 6. All were sold. And none remain.

Peafowl

The same answers for 3 peahens that remained. And he accounts for the same as paid to Wargrave,⁴⁹⁴ by order of the lord, by John Seint Jon. And it equals.

Cocks and hens

The same answers for 5 cocks and 5 hens received from a fixed rent called 'churchscot' at Christmas. And sold as within. And it equals.

White-tawed leather

The same answers for a quarter piece of 1 white-tawed hide that remained. And he accounts for all in mending a cart harness. And nothing remains.

Raw hides

The same answers for 3 hides of 2⁴⁹⁵ affers as above from the murrain of affers. And all were sold as within. And it equals.

Wool

The same answers for 239 woollen fleeces coming from shearing of sheep and not more because 1 wether [died] in murrain before shearing. Sum 239. And all remained under the seal of the prior of Sandon.

⁴⁹⁴ One of the bishop's Berkshire manors.

⁴⁹⁵ An error for '3'.

Woolfells and bare pelts

The same answers for 1 woolfell of a wether and 2 bare pelts from murrain as above. Sum 3. And sold as within. And none remain.

Litter and straw

The same answers for 17 days worth⁴⁹⁶ of straw received from John Seint John by tally, under a fixed price, from the rectory of Cobham. Sum 17 days. And he accounts for all paid for the expenses of the lord's household by one indenture but not under the same price because it was inspected by the steward of the lord's house [and] he valued it less dearly. And it equals.

From issue of the garden nothing is answered for here.

30. 30 September 1336 to 29 September 1337

The accounts for the mid-1330s generally give the impression that seigneurial optimism about the manor of Esher was returning. The demesne, for example, was restocked with sheep for the first time in over 20 years and cropped acreage began to expand again after a lull of the same duration. Moreover, building projects were undertaken that, as in the late thirteenth century, suggest a confident assertion of status. In this account, for example, the chapel was scaffolded and mended by a mason using large freestones that were carted from Reigate to Esher by tenants of Merton Priory. Freestone, which is fine-grained and can easily be carved, was used for tracery around windows and doors, and Reigate stone was used extensively in high status buildings in and around medieval and Tudor London.⁴⁹⁷ In addition, a dovecot was constructed, the roof of which was louvred and covered with 5,000 tiles. In itself, this was not an unusual addition to a demesne; yet, even on other high-ranking estates, freestanding dovecots at this time were often thatched.⁴⁹⁸ However, seigneurial confidence about the future must have been dented to some extent by the developing political and economic context, for this period witnessed the naval jockeying, military breast-beating, and economic strictures that accompanied the start of the Hundred Years' War with France. Indeed, the French fleet had been threatening the southern and eastern coasts of England for much of 1336, and the spring and summer of 1337 brought the raising of armies on both sides and a royal indenture on the sale of wool. Although never explicitly linked, the Esher account for 1336/7 contains several plausible indications that growing hostilities were having an effect on local manorial management: the bridge to the *curia* was renewed and the locks on the great gate mended; wool from the sheep flock was retained rather than being sold; and the price of herrings, which had remained steadfastly stable during the agricultural turmoil of the preceding decades, suddenly shot up during the harvest of 1337.⁴⁹⁹ Nor was this the only destabilising force. In September 1336 a bailiff took over sole charge of running the demesne at Esher and remained in post for five years. The reason for this change and the effects it wrought are difficult to perceive in these

⁴⁹⁶ In MS, '*dietis*'.

⁴⁹⁷ Examples can still be found at the Tower of London and Hampton Court Palace.

⁴⁹⁸ Stone, 'Consumption and supply of birds', p. 156.

⁴⁹⁹ See also Stone, *Decision-making in medieval agriculture*, pp. 191–2.